

Video calls and live streaming — on WhatsApp, Zoom, TikTok Live, Facebook Live, IMO and similar apps — are now part of everyday family life in Sri Lanka, from talking to relatives abroad to online classes. They bring real benefits, but also risks every parent should understand and guide their child through.

TOP TIPS FOR PARENTS

- 1 Think before video chatting**
 Anything visible on camera — including things in the background — can reveal personal information. Video can be recorded and shared without your child's knowledge, so teach them to behave as if every call could be saved.
- 2 Be careful with online “friends”**
 Video chat requests from strangers should be treated with caution. A face on screen may not belong to the person your child thinks they are speaking to. Turn on privacy settings to control who can make contact.
- 3 Report and block harmful content**
 Some apps allow chatting with strangers and may expose children to violent, sexual or otherwise inappropriate content. Report this to the app immediately and block the user.
- 4 It is always okay to say no**
 No one should ever be pressured into a dare, undressing, or sexual behaviour on camera. Such footage can be recorded and used for blackmail (“sextortion”). Make sure your child knows they can refuse, end the call, and tell you — it is never too late to speak up.
- 5 Talk regularly, not just once**
 Make online safety a normal part of family conversation, so your child feels comfortable coming to you the moment something feels wrong.

GUIDANCE BY AGE GROUP

5–9 yrs

Only video call approved family members with you present or nearby. Keep devices in shared living spaces, never bedrooms, and set up parental controls on all apps.

10–13 yrs

Agree on which apps are allowed and who they may add. Check privacy settings together and keep reminding them that new online contacts must be told to you before any call.

14–17 yrs

Give more independence but keep communication open. Discuss peer pressure, sextortion scams, and what to do if a call or livestream turns uncomfortable. Revisit house rules regularly.

QUICK CHECKLIST BEFORE HANDING OVER A DEVICE

- ☐ Privacy settings are turned on and the account is not searchable by strangers.
- ☐ You know every app on the device that can make video calls or livestream.
- ☐ The camera is covered or the device is closed when not in use.
- ☐ Your child knows the family rule: no video calls with people you haven't approved.
- ☐ Your child knows they can come to you about anything online without getting into trouble.
- ☐ You have saved the 1929 Child Helpline number in your phone.

HOW TO TALK TO YOUR CHILD ABOUT THIS

Children open up when the conversation feels calm, regular and judgement-free — not like a one-time warning. Try these approaches:

► **Start early and keep it casual** — Bring it up during everyday moments — while watching TV together or after they finish a video call — rather than as a formal sit-down lecture.

► **Ask, don't interrogate** — Use open questions like the ones below instead of yes/no questions, so your child does the talking.

“Who did you talk to online today?”

“Has anyone you don't know ever asked to video call you?”

“What would you do if someone on camera asked you to do something that made you uncomfortable?”

► **Promise no blame, no phone confiscation as punishment** — Children often stay silent about problems because they fear losing their device. Reassure them that telling you will never get them in trouble.

► **Praise them for telling you** — Whenever your child reports something uncomfortable online, thank them calmly — this builds trust for the next time.

► **Set expectations together** — Agree as a family on simple house rules for video calls: who they can call, when, and that an adult is always told about new online contacts.

WARNING SIGNS TO WATCH FOR

- ⚠ Your child becomes secretive about their phone or laptop, or switches screens quickly when you walk in.
- ⚠ They receive gifts, mobile credit, or money from an online contact you don't recognise.
- ⚠ Sudden anxiety, withdrawal, or reluctance to go to school after using video chat apps.
- ⚠ They avoid webcam calls with family after previously being comfortable with them.
- ⚠ Unknown adults or older “friends” appearing repeatedly in their contact list.

SETTING UP CONTROLS ON POPULAR APPS

WhatsApp	Set “Who can see my info” and “Who can add me to groups” to “My Contacts” under Settings > Privacy.
TikTok	Turn on Family Pairing and set the account to Private so only approved followers can message or duet.
YouTube	Use YouTube Kids or Supervised Experiences, and turn off livestreaming for under-13 accounts.
Zoom / Google Meet	Use Waiting Rooms and never share meeting links publicly, so only invited people can join a call.

WHERE TO GET HELP IN SRI LANKA



1929 CHILD HELPLINE

Free, 24-hour, trilingual line run by the NCPA for any child abuse concern, including online abuse. complaints@childprotection.gov.lk



POLICE EMERGENCY — 119

Call 119, or visit your nearest Police Children & Women's Bureau to file a complaint in person.



SRI LANKA CERT

Report hacking, malware or online exploitation directly at cert.gov.lk.



IN AN EMERGENCY

Keep your child safe first, preserve evidence (screenshots), then report to 1929 or the police right away.